Opinions & honesty

A conversational idiom workbook: 11 phrases, each with a short conversation and four quick tasks. Do it online and check your answers, or print it and use the answer key at the end.

In this workbook

1. **chances are**: It is likely that something is true or will happen.
2. **Don't get me wrong**: A phrase you say before a 'but' to stop someone from misunderstanding you.
3. **for lack of a better way of putting it**: Said when you can't find the perfect words, so you use the closest ones.
4. **I hate to break it to you**: A polite way to start telling someone news they may not like.
5. **just saying**: A light phrase you add after a comment to say you don't want to argue or cause trouble.
6. **pass the sniff test**: To seem good, honest or believable when you check it.
7. **point blank**: In a direct, straightforward way, without hesitating or being polite first.
8. **splitting hairs**: Arguing about a tiny difference that is not important.
9. **to tell you the truth**: A phrase you use before saying something honest, especially when it may be a little surprising.
10. **that's neither here nor there**: That point is not important or not relevant to what we are discussing.
11. **You would think (that)…**: Used when you expect something to be true or happen, but in reality it doesn't.

How to use it: read the conversation out loud first, then do the four tasks. For the last task, answer out loud before you write, and try to use the phrase naturally.

chances are

Expression · Level B1 · Neutral

It is likely that something is true or will happen.

Tip: Use it at the start of a sentence, followed by a full clause ("Chances are he's already left"); it's a prediction, so don't use it for things you know for certain.

Olena: Did Kofi reply about Saturday? I need to know how many chairs to borrow.

Mei: Not yet. He's been working late all week.

Olena: So is he coming or not?

Mei: Chances are he'll come. He never misses a birthday.

Olena: Okay, I'll plan for ten people, then.

1. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "chances are he'll come" mean?

- ○ A. He has been given a chance to come.
- ○ B. He has definitely said yes.
- ○ C. He will probably come.
- ○ D. He might get a chance to choose.

2. Fill the gap

I've left three messages for the plumber, so _____ he's busy with another job.

3. Choose the best reply

Diego: *Do you think Amira will like the gift I bought her?*

- ○ A. Chances are she gave it to you yesterday.
- ○ B. Chances are she will. It's exactly her style.
- ○ C. She will have a chance of it next week.

4. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you had to guess what someone would do. What happened?

Don't get me wrong

Expression | Level B1 | Neutral

A phrase you say before a 'but' to stop someone from misunderstanding you.

Tip: Say it before you give a criticism or a different opinion, then follow it with 'but'; it softens what comes next, so don't use it for good news.

Olena: So, what did you think of the new flat? You've been quiet since we left.

Kofi: Don't get me wrong, the kitchen is lovely, but the bus stop is twenty minutes away.

Olena: True, that's a long walk, especially in winter.

Kofi: And the rent is already at the top of what I can pay.

Olena: Then maybe keep looking. There's no rush, right?

5. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "Don't get me wrong" mean?

- ○ A. I am telling you that you made a mistake about the flat.
- ○ B. I am asking you not to take the kitchen from me.
- ○ C. I am saying that I will not rent the flat under any condition.
- ○ D. I want you to understand that I like the kitchen, even though I have a problem with the flat.

6. Fill the gap

_____, I really enjoyed the trip, but I wouldn't go back in summer because it was far too hot.

7. Choose the best reply

Amira: *You don't seem very excited about the new software at work. Do you hate it?*

- ○ A. Don't get me wrong, I hate it, and I hate it very much.
- ○ B. Don't get me wrong, it's useful, but it takes me a long time to learn all the buttons.
- ○ C. Don't get me wrong, thank you for the software, and I will use it tomorrow.

8. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a place you have lived in or visited that you liked, but that wasn't perfect.

_____

_____

_____

for lack of a better way of putting it

Expression | Level B2 | Neutral

Said when you can't find the perfect words, so you use the closest ones.

Tip: Put it in the middle of a sentence, usually before a description you know isn't perfect; it's often set off with commas, and don't use it when you actually have the exact word.

Amira: So, how was the new manager's first team meeting?

Ken: Interesting. She's, for lack of a better way of putting it, very hands-on.

Amira: Hands-on? You mean she checks everything?

Ken: Pretty much. She asked to see our drafts before we'd even finished them.

Amira: Hmm. That might get tiring after a while.

Ken: It might. But she does seem to care about the work.

9. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "for lack of a better way of putting it" mean?

- ○ A. I'm repeating what someone else said earlier.
- ○ B. I don't have enough information to give my opinion.
- ○ C. I'm trying to say something politely because I don't want to criticise.
- ○ D. I can't think of a more exact way to say this, so this is close enough.

10. Fill the gap

The hotel was, _____, a bit of an adventure: the lift was broken and the room was tiny.

11. Choose the best reply

Olena: *So what's your new flatmate like?*

- ○ A. He is for lack of a better way of putting it, because I don't know anything about him.
- ○ B. Well, for lack of a better way of putting it, he's very tidy. Almost too tidy!
- ○ C. For lack of a better way of putting it, I'm going to the shop now.

12. Your turn: speak

Describe a place you have visited that was very different from what you expected.

_____

_____

_____

I hate to break it to you

Expression | Level B2 | Neutral

A polite way to start telling someone news they may not like.

Tip: Say it just before the bad news, then add 'but' and the news: 'I hate to break it to you, but...'; use it with people you want to stay kind to, and don't use it for good news.

Olena: Are we still meeting Kofi at the station at six? I've got our tickets ready.

Diego: I hate to break it to you, but his train was cancelled. He just texted me.

Olena: Oh no. Is he coming later, or not at all?

Diego: Later. He's on the nine o'clock one, so he'll miss the first half of the film.

Olena: Okay, let's go anyway and he can meet us for dinner afterwards.

13. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "I hate to break it to you" mean?

- ○ A. Diego is sorry that he physically broke something of Olena's.
- ○ B. Diego is asking Olena to tell Kofi some news for him.
- ○ C. Diego is gently introducing news that Olena probably won't like.
- ○ D. Diego is saying he dislikes Olena and wants to end the plan.

14. Fill the gap

_____, but the meeting has been moved to eight o'clock tomorrow morning.

15. Choose the best reply

Amira: *Ken: I'm sure my landlord will give me my deposit back in full, even with the mark on the carpet.*

- ○ A. I hate to break it to you, and I'm really happy that you're moving out.
- ○ B. I hate to break it to you, but they usually take money off for stains like that.
- ○ C. I hate to break it to you, so congratulations on getting the whole deposit back!

16. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you had to give someone news they didn't want to hear. How did you handle it?

_____

_____

_____

just saying

Expression · Level B2 · Casual

A light phrase you add after a comment to say you don't want to argue or cause trouble.

Tip: Add it at the end of a comment, often with a falling tone, to soften an opinion or a warning; it's casual, so avoid it in formal writing or serious complaints.

Olena: Are you really going to leave for the airport at six? Your flight isn't until nine.

Kofi: Yeah, I hate rushing. I'd rather wait at the gate.

Olena: Fair enough. But the motorway is always packed on Friday mornings.

Kofi: Hmm, that's true. Last time it took me almost two hours.

Olena: Exactly. I'm just saying. Leave when you like, of course.

Kofi: No, I'll go at five thirty. Thanks for the warning.

17. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "I'm just saying" mean?

- ○ A. Olena is repeating her words because Kofi didn't hear her.
- ○ B. Olena is angry and wants Kofi to change his plan immediately.
- ○ C. Olena is giving a gentle warning and doesn't want to start an argument.
- ○ D. Olena is asking Kofi to explain his decision to her.

18. Fill the gap

Those shoes might not be warm enough for the hike tomorrow. _____ ,

but it can get really cold up there.

19. Choose the best reply

Amira: *You're going to wear that thin coat to the mountains? It's supposed to snow.*

- ○ A. I'm just saying you must never buy that coat again.
- ○ B. Just saying, please repeat what you said, I didn't hear.
- ○ C. Just saying, but you might want to bring something warmer.

20. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you gave a friend or colleague some advice they didn't ask for. How did you say it?

_____

_____

_____

pass the sniff test

Idiom | Level B2 | Casual

To seem good, honest or believable when you check it.

Tip: Use it about claims, stories, offers or plans: 'That doesn't pass the sniff test.' Don't use it for people's smell, and don't say 'pass the sniff' on its own.

Olena: Did you see that flat listing? Two bedrooms near the station for half the usual rent.

Kofi: I did. The photos look great, but the owner wants a deposit before anyone can visit.

Olena: Hmm. That's a bit odd.

Kofi: Exactly. The whole thing doesn't pass the sniff test for me.

Olena: Agreed. Let's keep looking and only pay after we've seen a place in person.

21. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "doesn't pass the sniff test" mean?

- ○ A. It doesn't seem believable or trustworthy when you look at it closely
- ○ B. It was advertised badly and few people have seen it
- ○ C. It is too expensive for most people to afford
- ○ D. It has a bad smell that people notice straight away

22. Fill the gap

The company's claim that its new phone battery lasts a week _____, so I'm going to read some independent reviews before I buy.

23. Choose the best reply

Amira: *My cousin says he'll double my money in a month if I send him some cash for his new business.*

- ○ A. Well, he should sniff the test before he asks anyone for money.
- ○ B. Great, it passed the sniff test, so you should send it today.
- ○ C. Honestly, that doesn't pass the sniff test. I'd want to see real proof first.

24. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you saw an offer, a message or a story online that you didn't fully trust. What did you do?

_____

_____

_____

point blank

Idiom | Level B2 | Neutral

In a direct, straightforward way, without hesitating or being polite first.

Tip: Use it with verbs of asking, telling or refusing (ask, tell, say, refuse point blank); it goes after the verb or object, and it's not used for describing a person's character.

Amira: Did you ever find out why the landlord kept putting off the repairs?

Kofi: Yes, I got tired of the excuses, so I asked him point blank.

Amira: And what did he say?

Kofi: He admitted he didn't have the money yet. At least I know where I stand now.

Amira: That's better than waiting another month for an answer.

25. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "point blank" mean?

- ○ A. Angrily, in a loud voice
- ○ B. In writing, so there is a record
- ○ C. Several times, over a long period
- ○ D. Directly, without hinting or being careful first

26. Fill the gap

When the manager asked Olena if she was happy in the role, she told him _____ that she wanted more responsibility.

27. Choose the best reply

Mei: *Ken keeps avoiding the question about who broke the printer. What should I do?*

- ○ A. Wait until he points blank at you first.
- ○ B. Be point blank with the printer and see if it works.
- ○ C. Just ask him point blank. Then he can't dodge it.

28. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you had to ask someone a difficult question directly.

splitting hairs

Idiom | Level B2 | Casual

Arguing about a tiny difference that is not important.

Tip: Use it as a verb phrase: 'You're splitting hairs' or 'Let's not split hairs'; it can sound dismissive, so be careful when saying it directly to someone senior.

Olena: Did you read Kofi's report? He says sales rose by 'nearly 12 percent'.

Ken: It was 11.8. He should have written 'almost 12'.

Olena: Ken, you're splitting hairs. The point is that sales went up.

Ken: Fair enough. I just like numbers to be exact.

Olena: I know, but the client only wants the big picture today.

29. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'splitting hairs' mean?

- ○ A. Arguing about a very small difference that doesn't really matter
- ○ B. Making a serious mistake in a report
- ○ C. Dividing a big task into smaller parts
- ○ D. Disagreeing strongly about an important fact

30. Fill the gap

We both want the blue sofa, so choosing between two almost identical shades of blue is just _____.

31. Choose the best reply

Amira: *I know you said 'around eight', but it's actually 8:10, so you were late.*

- ○ A. That's a good idea. I'll split hairs with you at 8:10.
- ○ B. Yes, I'm splitting hairs, so I'll cut my hair before eight.
- ○ C. Come on, now you're splitting hairs. It's only ten minutes.

32. Your turn: speak

Do you know anyone who pays too much attention to small details? Tell me about them.

to tell you the truth

Expression · Level B1 · Casual

A phrase you use before saying something honest, especially when it may be a little surprising.

Tip: Put it at the start of a sentence and follow it with a comma; it often introduces an opinion or a fact the other person may not expect, so keep your tone friendly.

Amira: Ken, did you finish that thriller I lent you?

Ken: Not yet. To tell you the truth, I stopped after about fifty pages.

Amira: Really? I thought you'd love it. It gets so much better in the middle.

Ken: Maybe. The story just felt slow to me, and I never got interested in the characters.

Amira: That's fine. Give it another try when you're on holiday, and if it's still not for you, just pass it on.

Ken: Good idea. Thanks for not being offended.

33. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "to tell you the truth" mean?

- ○ A. I am going to say something honest that may surprise you.
- ○ B. I am swearing to a judge that I'm honest.
- ○ C. I am repeating something I already told you.
- ○ D. I want to prove that my earlier statements were lies.

34. Fill the gap

_____, I didn't really enjoy the party last night, so I left early.

35. Choose the best reply

Olena: *Do you like the new design for our team's website?*

- ○ A. I'll tell you the truth, then you tell me a lie.
- ○ B. To tell you the truth, the menu is a bit confusing for me.
- ○ C. To tell you the truth, you should ask me again later in the truth.

36. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a type of food you didn't like at first but enjoy now.

_____

_____

_____

that's neither here nor there

Idiom | Level B2 | Neutral

That point is not important or not relevant to what we are discussing.

Tip: Use it after you mention a fact that is true but does not affect the decision, often with 'but' before it: 'It's expensive, but that's neither here nor there.' Don't use it for something that is simply false or unimportant to you personally; it means irrelevant to the topic being discussed.

Olena: I think we should book the second hotel. The reviews are better.

Diego: True, but it's twenty minutes from the station. That's a long walk with suitcases.

Olena: Well, we'll take a taxi anyway. And it's a bit older, but that's neither here nor there.

Diego: Okay, so what matters is the price and the breakfast.

Olena: Exactly. The second one is cheaper and breakfast is included.

Diego: Fine, let's book it.

37. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "that's neither here nor there" mean?

- ○ A. Olena and Diego disagree about the hotel.
- ○ B. The age of the hotel is not important for their decision.
- ○ C. Olena is not sure whether the hotel is old or new.
- ○ D. The hotel is not in either of the two places they are discussing.

38. Fill the gap

Yes, I forgot to reply to your email last week, but that's _____ now. We need to fix the schedule today.

39. Choose the best reply

Ken: *You know, the new manager wears the same jacket every day.*

- ○ A. Yes, the jacket is neither here nor there, so it's not in the office.
- ○ B. Yes, and that's neither here nor there. I'll buy a jacket just like it.
- ○ C. Yes, and that's neither here nor there. What matters is whether she listens to us.

40. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you had to make a decision, such as choosing a place to live or study. What factors mattered most to you?

You would think (that)...

Expression · Level B2 · Neutral

Used when you expect something to be true or happen, but in reality it doesn't.

Tip: Follow it with a clause describing the logical expectation, then use 'but' or 'yet' to say what really happened; it often signals mild frustration or surprise.

Olena: Did you get an answer from the landlord about the broken heater?

Kofi: Not yet. I've emailed him three times this week.

Olena: Three times? You would think he'd reply to at least one of them.

Kofi: I know. It's been freezing in the flat since Monday.

Olena: Maybe try calling him. People often answer the phone faster than email.

Kofi: Good idea. I'll ring him after lunch.

41. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "You would think he'd reply to at least one of them" mean?

- ○ A. Olena is asking Kofi to think carefully about who to email.
- ○ B. Olena expects the landlord to reply, but he hasn't, and that surprises or annoys her.
- ○ C. Olena is guessing that the landlord has probably replied already.
- ○ D. Olena believes the landlord is too busy to answer emails.

42. Fill the gap

_____ a company that size would have a working website, but I couldn't even log in to book my appointment.

43. Choose the best reply

Amira: *I've been waiting forty minutes at the pharmacy, and they still haven't called my name.*

- ○ A. You would think they'd be quicker, since it's not even busy today.
- ○ B. You would think me waiting forty minutes is a good thing.
- ○ C. You would think and then ask the pharmacist politely.

44. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when something didn't go the way you expected, even though it should have been easy.

Answer key

chances are

1. C. He will probably come.
2. chances are
3. B. Chances are she will. It's exactly her style.
4. Example: Last year my friend didn't answer my calls before a trip, so I had to guess whether he'd be at the station. Chances are he was still packing, I thought, because he always leaves things to the last minute. I was right, and he arrived five minutes before the train.

Don't get me wrong

5. D. I want you to understand that I like the kitchen, even though I have a problem with the flat.
6. Don't get me wrong
7. B. Don't get me wrong, it's useful, but it takes me a long time to learn all the buttons.
8. Example: I spent a month in Lisbon last year. Don't get me wrong, I loved the food and the people, but the hills made walking around really tiring. I would still go back, maybe with better shoes.

for lack of a better way of putting it

9. D. I can't think of a more exact way to say this, so this is close enough.
10. for lack of a better way of putting it
11. B. Well, for lack of a better way of putting it, he's very tidy. Almost too tidy!
12. Example: I visited a small town last year that was, for lack of a better way of putting it, much quieter than I'd imagined. I'd expected cafés and shops, but by six o'clock almost everything was closed. In the end I actually enjoyed the peace.

I hate to break it to you

13. C. Diego is gently introducing news that Olena probably won't like.
14. I hate to break it to you
15. B. I hate to break it to you, but they usually take money off for stains like that.
16. Example: Last year my cousin was planning a surprise party, and I found out the venue had double-booked her date. I called her and said, 'I hate to break it to you, but we'll need a new place.' She was upset at first, but we found another venue that same afternoon, so it worked out fine.

just saying

17. C. Olena is giving a gentle warning and doesn't want to start an argument.
18. Just saying
19. C. Just saying, but you might want to bring something warmer.
20. Example: Last month my colleague was about to send a long email to a client without checking the numbers. I said, "Maybe look at the figures again. Just saying!" She laughed, checked, and found a small mistake, so I was glad I spoke up.

pass the sniff test

21. A. It doesn't seem believable or trustworthy when you look at it closely
22. doesn't pass the sniff test
23. C. Honestly, that doesn't pass the sniff test. I'd want to see real proof first.
24. Example: Last month I got a message saying I'd won a free holiday, but I hadn't entered any competition. It just didn't pass the sniff test, so I checked the company's real website and found nothing about it. I deleted the message and told my family to ignore anything similar.

point blank

25. D. Directly, without hinting or being careful first
26. point blank
27. C. Just ask him point blank. Then he can't dodge it.
28. Example: A few months ago my flatmate kept hinting that she might move out, and I couldn't plan my budget. In the end I asked her point blank whether she was staying. It felt awkward for a minute, but she said yes, and we both felt relieved.

splitting hairs

29. A. Arguing about a very small difference that doesn't really matter
30. splitting hairs
31. C. Come on, now you're splitting hairs. It's only ten minutes.
32. Example: My brother is like that. When we plan a trip, he argues about whether to leave at 7:00 or 7:15, and honestly, I think he's splitting hairs. But his attention to detail does help when we book tickets.

to tell you the truth

33. A. I am going to say something honest that may surprise you.
34. To tell you the truth
35. B. To tell you the truth, the menu is a bit confusing for me.
36. Example: To tell you the truth, I couldn't stand mushrooms when I was a kid because of the texture. But a friend cooked them with garlic and butter a few years ago, and now I order them all the time.

that's neither here nor there

37. B. The age of the hotel is not important for their decision.
38. neither here nor there
39. C. Yes, and that's neither here nor there. What matters is whether she listens to us.
40. Example: When I chose my university, the most important things were the course and the cost. The campus was quite ugly, but that was neither here nor there for me, because the teaching was excellent. I'm glad I focused on what really mattered.

You would think (that)…

41. B. Olena expects the landlord to reply, but he hasn't, and that surprises or annoys her.
42. You would think
43. A. You would think they'd be quicker, since it's not even busy today.
44. Example: Last month I tried to renew my passport online. You would think a government website would make it simple, but the form kept crashing, and in the end I had to go in person. It took me half a day instead of ten minutes.